



Red-letter day: Pranav Soorma battled illness on the eve of competition but still hurled his way to silver in the men's club throw F51 at Paris 2024 — part of India's historic one-two finish in athletics. GETTYIMAGES

government bank job, I decided to leave athletics.

But God had other plans. In 2022, Giriraj sir persuaded me to give it another shot and introduced me to Naval sir. That meeting changed my life.

Naval sir had been coaching for 15 years and knew not only how to train but also how to map an athlete's entire journey: how to secure sponsors and how to fight the battles that mattered. After our first month together, he told me to bring a new diary. On the first page, he wrote: 'Pranav Soorma, Asian Para Games gold medal, Paralympic medal, Asian record holder, World

record holder.'

I laughed and told him, "Sir, I've just started. Is this even possible?" He replied, "I know how to dream. I know how to show dreams. And I know how to fulfill them."

The only condition was belief. If he said night was day, I had to believe him. If he told me to train at 3 a.m., I had to do it. And he was right. I went on to win Asian Para Games gold with an Area record, and then a Paralympic silver in Club Throw F51.

I still write in that diary; my achievements, my goals, and my gratitude to God. When people ask who inspires me, I don't have to look anywhere else.

Destiny, too, plays its part. My surname, Soorma, means the ultimate fighter in Punjabi. I believe it's in my blood to fight till the end. That's why I brand my name everywhere — on my wheelchair, my T-shirt, even my caps. I want people to see it. And now, they do.

Since Paris, my life has changed. My medal brought happiness to my family and pride to my country. I received the Arjuna Award earlier this year. People who once doubted me, saying I would never amount to anything, that I was just dependent on my family — now ask to take pictures with me. I see the change in their eyes: This boy has done something.

The silver medal hangs framed on my wall. I look at it often. But I don't think it's my biggest achievement. The real achievement is that I never gave up. After my accident, I wanted to quit on life itself. I thought it had no meaning. But I kept moving forward.

Today, I am alive, competing, and winning. The Paralympic medal and Arjuna Award are rewards, but the greatest victory is showing up every day and living life as it's meant to be lived.

As told to Jonathan Selvaraj